



The Nature of the Gods and Greek Religion

This only is denied to God: the power to undo the past.

—ARISTOTLE,

Nicomachean Ethics 6.2.4 (quoting the playwright Agathon)

Anthropomorphism

By now the nature of the anthropomorphic conception of deity that evolved among the Greeks and the Romans should be evident. The gods are generally depicted as human in form and character; but although they look and act like humans, very often their appearance and their actions are to some extent idealized. Their beauty is beyond that of ordinary mortals, their passions are more grand and intense, their sentiments more praiseworthy and touching; and they can embody and impose the loftiest moral values in the universe. Yet these same gods can mirror the physical and spiritual weaknesses of human counterparts: they can be lame and deformed or vain, petty, and insincere; they can steal, lie, and cheat, sometimes with a finesse that is exquisitely divine.

The gods usually live in houses on Mt. Olympus or in heaven; a very important distinction, however, is to be made between those deities of the upper air and the upper world (the Olympians) and those of the realm below, appropriately named **chthonian** (i.e., of the earth). They eat and drink, but their food is **ambrosia** and their wine **nectar**. **Ichor** (a substance clearer than blood) flows in their veins. Just as they can feel the gamut of human emotion, so too they can suffer physical pain and

torment. They are worshiped in shrines, temples, and sanctuaries; they are honored with statues, placated by sacrifices, and invoked by prayers.

In general, the gods are more versatile than mortals. They are able to move with amazing speed and dexterity, appear and disappear in a moment, and change their shape at will, assuming various forms—human, animal, and divine. Their powers also are far greater than those of mortals. Yet gods are seldom omnipotent, except possibly for Zeus himself, and even Zeus may be made subject to Fate or the Fates. Their knowledge, too, is superhuman, if on occasion limited. Omniscience is most often reserved as a special prerogative of Zeus and Apollo, who communicate their knowledge of the future to mortals. Most important of all, the gods are immortal; in the last analysis, their immortality is the one divine characteristic that most consistently distinguishes them from mortals.

Very often one or more animals are associated with a particular deity. For Zeus, it is the eagle; for Hera, the peacock; for Poseidon, the horse; for Athena, the owl; for Aphrodite, the dove, sparrow, or goose; for Ares, the boar. In addition, a deity who desires to do so can take the form of an animal. There is no concrete evidence, however, to show that the Greeks at an early period ever worshiped animals as sacred.

The Divine Hierarchy

Many of the preceding remarks apply for the most part only to the highest order of divinity in the Greek pantheon. Such wondrous and terrible creations as the Gorgons or Harpies, who populate the universe to the enrichment of mythology and saga, obviously represent a different category of the supernatural. Of a different order, too, are the divine spirits who animate nature. These beings are usually depicted as nymphs—beautiful young girls who love to dance and sing and, in some cases, are extremely amorous. Very often nymphs act as attendants for one or more of the major gods or goddesses. The Muses are a kind of nymph, and so are the Nereids and Oceanids, although some of them assume virtually the stature of deity. More typically, nymphs are rather like fairies, extremely long-lived but not necessarily immortal.¹

Demigods are another class of superhuman beings, or better, a superior kind of human being—that is, supermen and superwomen. They are the offspring of mixed parentage, the union of a god with a mortal, who may or may not be extraordinary.² Demigods are therefore limited in their powers, which are rather less than those of full-fledged gods; and they are mortals, often little more than figures made larger than life because of their tragic and epic environment.

Heroes sometimes are demigods, but the terminology is not easy to define precisely. Mortals like Oedipus and Amphiaraüs are not, strictly speaking, demigods, although they are far from ordinary beings. They may be called heroes, and certainly they become so after death, honored with a cult largely because of the spiritual intensity of their lives and the miraculous nature of their deaths. They thus become associated with chthonic powers of the earth and can exert these powers to bless or curse from beyond the grave. For this reason, where a hero dies becomes a sacred place of cultic ritual in his honor. Heracles, too, is a hero and a demigod, but he is an exception because he joins

the company of the immortal gods on Olympus as a reward for his glorious attainments in this world. The difficulty in establishing absolute definitions is complicated further because of the use of the designation “hero” in the vocabulary of literary criticism. Achilles is a demigod, that is, the son of a mortal Peleus and the nymph-goddess Thetis. His powers are extraordinary, but it is ultimately as a mortal, the dramatic and epic hero of the *Iliad*, that he is to be judged.

It is apparent that a hierarchy of divinities existed in the Greek pantheon. The Olympians, along with the major deities of the lower world, represent as it were a powerful aristocracy. Although individual gods and goddesses may be especially honored in particular places (e.g., Athena in Athens, Hera in Argos, Hephaestus in Lemnos, Apollo in Delos and Delphi), in general the major divinities were universally recognized throughout the Greek world. At the top is Zeus himself, the king, the father of both gods and mortals, the supreme lord.

Polytheism for the Greeks, however, could also be quite expansive. It usually (though not always) could make room for new divinities without shock or strain. When they encountered foreign divinities, such as in Egypt or the Near East, the Greeks might recognize them as familiar deities and accept them into their pantheon or be willing to import a completely new god or goddess, if they so desired. This is not possible within a purely monotheist religion such as Judaism, Christianity, or Islam.

Zeus and Monotheism

We have already seen the popular anthropomorphic conception of Zeus as the father, husband, and lover; and we know too the primary sphere of his power: the sky and the upper air, with their thunder, lightning, and rain. Zeus also becomes the god who upholds the highest moral values in the order of the universe—values that he absorbs unto himself or that are divided among and shared by other deities. He is the god who protects the family, the clan, and the state, championing the universal moral and ethical responsibilities that these human associations entail. He protects suppliants, imposes ties of hospitality, upholds the sanctity of oaths; in a word, he is the defender of all that is right or just in the mores of advanced civilization.

Thus, within the polytheistic cast of Greek and Roman mythology and religion, a strong element of monotheism emerges from the very beginning. As it evolves, it may be linked closely to the standard depictions of an anthropomorphic Zeus or imagined in terms of more abstract philosophical and religious theories of a supreme power, as philosophical and religious thought become more sophisticated.

In Homer and Hesiod, Zeus is unquestionably the sovereign deity, and he is very much concerned with moral values. Yet his monotheism and patriarchy are severely tested by other divinities, especially goddesses. Hera’s power is able to thwart Zeus’ plans. Aphrodite can bend all the gods to her will, Zeus included, except for the three virgins, Hestia, Athena, and Artemis. Demeter, angry at the rape of her daughter Persephone, forces Zeus and the gods to come to her terms. And Zeus must yield to Fate or the Fates, although this need not always be the case.

At the same time, in the evolution of Zeus as the one supreme god, the almighty god of morality and justice, he could be referred to without a name and simply as god in an abstract, rather than specific, anthropomorphic conception. This greater sophistication in thought, which gave Zeus a more unquestionable, absolute, and spiritual authority, came about through the writings of religious poets and philosophers. Many selections from many authors could be quoted to bear testimony to the variety and complexity of Greek conceptions of the nature of the one god. A few examples must suffice.

Hesiod, who preaches a hard message of righteousness and warns of the terror of Zeus' punishment of the wicked, sounds very much like a severe prophet of the Old Testament. The opening section of his *Works and Days* includes the following lines (3–7):

Through Zeus, who dwells in a most lofty home and thunders from on high and by his mighty will, mortals are both known and unknown, renowned and unre-nowned; for easily he makes them strong and easily he brings them low; easily he makes the overweening humble and champions the obscure; easily he makes the crooked straight and strikes down the haughty.

Xenophanes, a poet and philosopher of the pre-Socratic period, was vehement in his attack on the conventional anthropomorphic depictions of the gods. He argued against the folly of conceiving deities as human beings and insisted that there is one supreme nonanthropomorphic god:

Homer and Hesiod have ascribed to the gods all that is shameful and reproachful among mortals: stealing, adultery, and deception. [frag. 11]

But mortals think that gods are born and have clothes and a voice and a body just like them. [frag. 14]

The Ethiopians say that their gods are flat-nosed and black and the Thracians that theirs are fair and ruddy. [frag. 16]

But if cattle and horses and lions had hands and could create with their hands and achieve works like those of human beings, horses would render their conceptions of the gods like horses, and cattle like cattle, and each would depict bodies for them just like their own. [frag. 15]

One god, greatest among gods and mortals, not at all like them, either in body or in mind. [frag. 23]

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The chorus of Aeschylus' *Agamemnon* (160–161) calls upon god by the name of Zeus with words that illustrate beautifully the universality of this supreme deity: "Zeus, whoever he may be, I call on him by this name, if it is pleasing to him to be thus invoked."

It is important to realize that monotheism and polytheism are not mutually exclusive and that human religious experience usually tends (as Xenophanes observes) to be anthropomorphic. It would be absurd to deny that Christianity in its very essence is monotheistic, but its monotheism, too, rests upon a hierarchical conception of the spiritual and physical universe, and its standard images are obviously cast in anthropomorphic molds: for example, there is one God in three divine persons, God the Father, the Son, and the Holy

Spirit; there are angels, saints, devils, and so on. This does not mean that the Christian philosopher and layperson view the basic tenets of their religion in exactly the same way; ultimately, each vision of deity is personal, as abstract and sublime for one as it is human and compassionate for another. Among Christian sects alone there are significant variations in dogma and ritual; and of course, there are those who do not believe at all. The range from devout belief to agnosticism and atheism was as diverse and rich in the ancient world as it is in our world. The tendency in a brief survey such as this is to oversimplify and distort.

Greek Humanism

The anthropomorphism of the Greeks is almost invariably linked to their role as the first great humanists. Humanism (the Greek variety or, for that matter, any other kind) can mean many things to many people. Standard interpretations usually evoke a few sublime (though hackneyed) quotations from Greek literature. The fifth-century sophist Protagoras is said to have proclaimed: “Man is the measure of all things.” Presumably, he is challenging absolute values by voicing new relativistic attitudes (i.e., mortals, not gods, are individual arbiters of the human condition). A chorus in Sophocles’ *Antigone* sings exultantly: “Wonders are many but none is more wonderful than man”; and Achilles’ judgment of the afterlife in Homer’s *Odyssey* quoted out of context (translated on p. 358) seems to affirm an unbridled optimism in the boundless hope and achievement possible in this life, as opposed to the dismal gloom and dull inertia of the hereafter. He cries out:

I should prefer as a slave to serve another man, even if he had no property and little to live on, than to rule all those dead who have done with life.

With words such as these ringing in one’s ears, it seems easy to postulate a Greek worship (even idolatry) of the human in a universe where mortals pay the gods the highest (but surely dubious) compliment of casting them in their own image.

Whatever truths this popular view may hold, it is far too one-dimensional and misleading to be genuinely meaningful and fair. In opposition to this myopic, uplifting faith in the potential of human endeavor to triumph against all divine odds, Greek literature and thought are shot through with a somber and awesome reverence for the supremacy of the gods and the inevitability of the Fates. A sense of predetermined destiny for each individual was analyzed in terms of the meaning and possibility of free will and independent action. There also developed a strong and realistic awareness of the miseries, uncertainties, and unpredictability of human life ordained by the gods. If we are lucky, our lives will be more blessed by happiness than doomed to misery. Still, the terrible vicissitudes of life lead to only one conclusion: It is better to be dead than alive. This tragic irony of man’s dilemma as both an independent agent and a plaything of fate and the pain and suffering of human existence were pitted against the conviction that mortals may reach glorious and triumphant heights in the face of dreadful uncertainties and terrors. This idealistic optimism and this realistic pessimism, these two seemingly irreconcilable points of view, account for a

unique humanism originated by the Greeks, with its emphasis on the beauty and wonder of mortal achievement, despite the horrible disasters that a vindictive god or fate may dispense at any moment.

Myth, Religion, and Philosophy

Another word of caution is in order about generalizations concerning Greek religious attitudes. It has been claimed that the Greeks had no Bible or strict dogma and (incredible as it may seem) no real sense of sin, or that they were innocently free and tolerant in their acceptance of new gods—what difference does one more make to a polytheist? One should not merely repeat stories (many of them from Ovid) and make pronouncement upon the spiritual adequacy or inadequacy of the theological convictions they are supposed to represent. Mythology, philosophy, and religion are inextricably entwined, and one must try to look at all the evidence. Homer offered to the Greeks (as Shakespeare offers to us) a literary bible of humanism that could on occasion be quoted like scripture; the mystery religions provided a dogma and ritual of a more exacting nature. Certainly, Hesiod pronounces his divine revelation with a vehement biblical authority.

Priests and priestesses devoted their lives to the service of the gods. The city-states upheld—by custom, tradition, and law—strict moral and ethical codes of behavior. If the stories of opposition to the new god Dionysus rest upon any stratum of historical truth, a foreign message of salvation was not always readily or easily accommodated, and one could be put to death (in Athens, of all places) on a charge of impiety. The Greeks thought profoundly about god, the immortality of the soul, and the meaning and consequences of vice and virtue. The Platonic myth of Er (translated in Chapter 15) is a terrifying vision of heaven and hell; as such, it is a religious document. Along with much other evidence, it shows that Greek philosophical thought can hold its own with that of any of the so-called higher religions.

The Legendary History of Herodotus

The historian Herodotus (fifth century B.C.) perhaps best represents Greek humanistic and religious attitudes in their clearest and most succinct form when he relates the story of Solon, Croesus, and Cyrus. Fortunately, episodes in this drama may be easily excerpted here, for they illustrate many things. Monotheism and polytheism are shown resting compatibly side by side. The jealous god of Solon is not unlike the wrathful deity of the Old Testament, a god who makes manifest to mortals that it is better to be dead than alive. The divine is able to communicate with mortals in a variety of ways; one can understand the simple and sincere belief in Apollo and Delphi possible in the sixth century B.C. There is a fascinating interplay between the inevitability of fate or destiny and the individuality of human character and free will.

Much that is Homeric has colored the Herodotean view, not least of all a compassion, tinged with a most profound sadness and pity, for the human condition. Homeric and dramatic, too, is the simple elucidation of the dangers of hubris and the irrevocable vengeance of Nemesis—the kernel, as it were, of a theme that dominates Greek tragedy. Herodotus, like most Greek writers,

takes his philosophy from Homer. In the last book of the *Iliad* (see pp. 497–498), Priam, great king of Troy, comes alone as a humble suppliant to the Greek hero Achilles to beg for the body of his son Hector, whom Achilles has killed. In the course of their interview, Achilles, who has also suffered much, not least of all because of the death of his beloved Patroclus, divulges his conclusions about human existence:

No human action is without chilling grief. For thus the gods have spun out for wretched mortals the fate of living in distress, while they live without care. Two jars sit on the doorsill of Zeus, filled with gifts that he bestows, one jar of evils, the other of blessing. When Zeus who delights in the thunder takes from both and mixes the bad with the good, a human being at one time encounters evil, at another good. But the one to whom Zeus gives only troubles from the jar of sorrows, this one he makes an object of abuse, to be driven by cruel misery over the divine earth.

For a translation of Bacchylides, see www.oup.com/us/morford.

The once mighty Priam will soon lose everything and meet a horrifying end, and Achilles himself is destined to die young. His fatalistic words about the uncertainty of human life are mirrored in the sympathetic humanism of Herodotus and echoed again and again by the Greek dramatists, who delight in the interplay of god and fate in human life and the tragic depiction of the mighty fall of those who were once great.

Herodotus' conception of a monotheistic god and his message of knowledge through suffering are strikingly Aeschylean. Herodotean themes *are* the very themes of Greek tragic literature: fate, god, and guilty and misguided mortals, who by their own actions try to avoid their destiny, only to further its fulfillment.

The story of **the death of Atys** is most Sophoclean in its movement and philosophy, and **Croesus, like Oedipus, fulfills his inevitable destinies in terms of his character**; each step that he takes in his blind attempts to avoid his fate brings him closer to its embrace. Most significantly,



Croesus on the Pyre. Attic red-figure amphora by Myson, ca. 500 B.C.; height 23 in. Croesus sits enthroned, wreathed, and holding his scepter. In his right hand he pours a libation from a *phiale*. An attendant, dressed (like Croesus) as a Greek and not as a Persian, lights the pyre. This is the earliest known version, in art or literature, of the story, and its narrative is similar to that of the poet Bacchylides, whose poem was written in 468 B.C., about thirty years before Herodotus' narrative. In this version, Croesus voluntarily erects the pyre to burn himself and his family rather than submit to loss of freedom. This is consistent with his elaborate dress and throne, with the ritual libation to Zeus and Apollo, and with the non-Persian attendant. Like Herodotus' Croesus, he is saved by a rainstorm, but he is then rewarded for his piety toward Apollo by being transported, with his family, to the land of the Hyperboreans. This scene was painted about fifty years after the capture of Sardis in 546 B.C.—a remarkable example of the transformation of an historical person into a mythical figure. For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

Croesus, again like Oedipus, can learn through sin and suffering to triumph against adversity and win reconciliation with god. There is not a single Greek tragedy that does not echo either implicitly or, in most cases, explicitly, the admonition of Solon, “Never count a person happy, until dead,” with its twofold connotation: the happiness of human life cannot be judged until the entire span of that life has been lived, and death is to be preferred to the vicissitudes of life.

Jack Miles, a former Jesuit, provides a Pulitzer Prize-winning study of the anthropomorphic God of the *Tanakh* (the Hebrew Bible).³ His literary portrait depicts God as a fictional character with many facets. To show that his contention is true, Miles retells the biblical story by presenting “the various personalities fused in the character of the Lord God” as separate characters. The result is a tale that reads very much like Greek and Roman mythology.

Yet there is no need to retell the story of the Old Testament polytheistically in order to reveal the essential similarity between the God of the Hebrews and the god of the Greeks. It is true that the *Tanakh* illustrates an absolute monotheism that appears more all-pervasive and relentless than that of the Greeks. Yet if we modify the major contention of Miles that for the Hebrews “all depends on a frighteningly unpredictable God” to read “all human happiness and misery depend on a frighteningly unpredictable God,” we are describing exactly the god of Homer and Herodotus.

The Tragedy of Croesus

Herodotus presents in the context of his *History of the Persian Wars* a brilliant crystallization of the tragic yet uplifting nature of Greek humanism, which can only be truly understood through the emotional and intellectual experience afforded by great art. He molds the legend of Croesus into a complete and powerful drama, conceived and beautifully executed within the disciplined structure of the short story. Herodotus is neither professional theologian nor philosopher, yet by his molding of traditional tales he sums up the spiritual essence of an age of faith and shows how history, mythology, and religion are for him inextricably one. The story of Solon’s meeting with Croesus is found in Book 1 of Herodotus (30.1–45.3):

THE MEETING BETWEEN SOLON AND CROESUS

And so Solon set out to see the world and came to the court of Amasis in Egypt and to Croesus at Sardis. And when he arrived, Croesus received him as a guest in his palace. Three or four days later at the bidding of Croesus, servants took Solon on a tour of his treasuries, pointing out that all of them were large and wealthy. When he had seen and examined them all to suit his convenience, Croesus asked the following question: “My Athenian guest, many stories about you have reached us because of your wisdom and your travels, of how you in your love of knowledge have journeyed to see many lands. And so now the desire has come over me to ask if by this time you have seen anyone who is the happiest.” He asked this expecting that he was the happiest of human beings, but Solon did not flatter him at all but following the truth said: “O king, **Tellus the Athenian.**” (30.1–30.3)

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Croesus, amazed at this reply, asked sharply: "How do you judge Tellus to be the most happy?" And Solon said: "First of all he was from a city that was faring well and he had beautiful and good children and to all of them he saw children born and all survive, and secondly his life was prosperous, according to our standards, and the end of his life was most brilliant. When a battle was fought by the Athenians against their neighbors near Eleusis, he went to help and after routing the enemy died most gloriously, and the Athenians buried him at public expense there where he fell and honored him greatly." Thus Solon provoked Croesus as he listed the many good fortunes that befell Tellus, and he asked whom he had seen second to him, thinking certainly that he would at least win second place. (30.4–31.1) 20

Solon said: "**Cleobis and Biton.** They were Argives by race, and their strength of body was as follows: both similarly carried off prizes at the festivals and as well this story is told. The Argives celebrated a festival to Hera. and it was absolutely necessary that the mother of these boys be brought by chariot to the temple.⁴ But the oxen had not come back from the fields in time, and the youths, because it was growing late, yoked themselves to the chariot and conveyed their mother, and after a journey of 5 miles they arrived at the temple. When they had done this deed, witnessed by the whole congregation, the end of life that befell them was the very best. And thereby god showed clearly how it is better for a human being to be dead than alive.⁵ For the Argive men crowded around and congratulated the youths for their strength and the women praised their mother for having such fine sons. And the mother was overjoyed at both the deed and the praise and standing in front of the statue prayed to the goddess to give to her sons, Cleobis and Biton, who had honored her greatly, the best thing for a human being to obtain. After this prayer, when they had sacrificed and feasted, the two young men went into the temple itself to sleep and never more woke up, but the end of death held them fast. The Argives had statues made of them and set them up in Delphi since they had been the best of men."⁶ (31.1–32.1) 40

Thus Solon assigned the second prize of happiness to these two, and Croesus interrupted in anger: "My Athenian guest, is our happiness so dismissed as nothing that you do not even put us on a par with ordinary men?" And he answered: "O Croesus, you ask me about human affairs, who know that all deity is jealous and fond of causing troubles. For in the length of time there is much to see that one does not wish and much to experience. For I set the limit on life at seventy years; these seventy years comprise 25,200 days, if an intercalary month is not inserted. But if one wishes to lengthen every other year by a month, so that the seasons will occur when they should, the months intercalated in the seventy years will number thirty-five and these additional months will add 1,050 days. All the days of the seventy years will total 26,250; and no one of them will bring exactly the same events as another. (32.1–32.4) 50

"And so then, O Croesus, a human being is completely a thing of chance.⁷ To me you appear to be wealthy and king of many subjects; but I cannot answer the question that you ask me until I know that you have completed the span of your life well. For the one who has great wealth is not at all more fortunate than the one who has only enough for his daily needs, unless fate attend him and, having everything that is fair, he also end his life well. For many very wealthy men are unfortunate and many with only moderate means 60

of livelihood have good luck. Indeed, the one who is very wealthy but unfortunate surpasses the lucky man in two respects only, but the man of good luck surpasses the wealthy but unlucky man in many. The latter [wealthy but unlucky] is better able to fulfill his desires and to endure a great disaster that might befall him, but the other man [who is lucky] surpasses him in the following ways. Although he is not similarly able to cope with doom and desire, good fortune keeps these things from him, and he is unmaimed, free from disease, does not suffer evils, and has fine children and a fine appearance. If in addition to these things he still ends his life well, this is the one whom you seek who is worthy to be called happy. Before he dies do not yet call him happy, but only fortunate. (32.4–32.8) 70

“Now it is impossible that anyone, since he is a man, gather unto himself all these blessings, just as no country is self-sufficient providing of itself all its own needs, but possesses one thing and lacks another. Whichever has the most, this is the best. Thus too no one human person is self-sufficient, for he possesses one thing but lacks another. Whoever continues to have most and then ends his life blessedly, this one justly wins this name from me, O king. One must see how the end of everything turns out. For to be sure, god gives a glimpse of happiness to many and then casts them down headlong.” 80
Solon did not find favor with Croesus by his words. He was sent away as one of no account, since Croesus was very much of the opinion that a man must be ignorant who sets aside present goods and bids one look to the end of everything. (32.8–33)

ATYS, ADRASTUS, AND THE BOAR HUNT

After the departure of Solon, a great Nemesis from god took hold of Croesus, very likely because he considered himself to be the happiest of all men. Straightway a dream stood before him as he slept, which made clear to him the truth of the evils that were to come about in connection with his son. Croesus had two sons, one of whom was mute, the other by far the first in all respects among youths of his own age. His name was **Atys**. The dream indicated to Croesus that this Atys would die struck by the point of an iron weapon. When he woke up, he thought about the dream and was afraid; he got his son a wife and, although the boy was accustomed to command the Lydian forces, he no longer sent him out on any such mission; and javelins and spears and all such weapons that men use in war he had removed from the men’s quarters and piled up in the women’s chambers, for fear that any that were hanging might fall on his son. (34.1–35.1) 90

While they had on their hands arrangements for the marriage, there came to Sardis a man seized with misfortune, his hands polluted with blood, a Phrygian by race and of the royal family. This man came to the palace of Croesus, and according to the traditions of the country begged to obtain purification, and Croesus purified him. The ritual of cleansing is similar for the Lydians and the Hellenes.⁸ When Croesus had performed the customary rites, he asked from where he came and who he was in the following words: “My fellow, who are you and from where in Phrygia have you come to my hearth? What man or woman have you killed?” And he answered: “O king, I am the son of Gordias, the son of Midas, and I am called **Adrastus**. I killed my 100



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brother unintentionally, and I come here driven out by my father and deprived of everything." (35.1–35.4)

Croesus answered him with these words: "You happen to be from a family of friends, and you have come to friends where you will want for nothing while you remain with us. It will be most beneficial to you to bear this misfortune as lightly as possible." So Adrastus lived in the palace of Croesus. (35.4–36.1) 110

At this very same time, a great monster of a boar appeared in Mysian Olympus, and he would rush down from this mountain and destroy the lands of the Mysians; often the Mysians went out against him but did him no harm and rather suffered from him. Finally, messengers of the Mysians came to Croesus and spoke as follows: "O king, the greatest monster of a boar has appeared in our country and destroys our lands. We are not able to capture him despite our great effort. Now then we beseech you to send your son to us and with him a picked company of young men and dogs so that we may drive him out of our land." (36.1–36.3) 120

They made this plea, but Croesus remembering the dream spoke the following words: "Do not mention my son further; for I will not send him to you; he is newly married and this now is his concern. I shall, however, send along a select group of Lydians and all my hunting equipment and hounds, and I shall order them as they go to be most zealous in helping you drive the beast from your land." (36.3–37.1)

This was his answer, and the Mysians were satisfied with it when the son of Croesus, who had heard their request, broke in on them. Croesus still refused to send his son along with them, and the young man spoke to him as follows: "O father, previously the finest and most noble pursuits were mine—to win renown in war and in the hunt. But now you have barred me from both, although you have not seen any lack of spirit or cowardice in me. Now how must I appear in the eyes of others as I go to and from the agora? What sort of man will I seem to my fellow citizens, what sort to my new bride? What kind of husband will she think she has married? So either let me go to the hunt or explain and convince me that it is better for me that things be done as you wish." (37.1–37.3) 130

Croesus answered with these words: "My child, I do not do this because I have seen in you cowardice or any other ugly trait, but the vision of a dream stood over me in sleep and said that your life would be short; for you will die by means of the sharp point of an iron weapon. And so in answer to the vision I urged this marriage on you and do not send you away on the present enterprise, being on my guard if in any way I might be able to steal you from fate for my own lifetime. For you happen to be my one and only child; for the other boy is deaf and I do not count him as mine."⁹ (38.1–39.1) 140

The young man answered: "O father, I forgive you for taking precautions for me since you have seen such a vision. But you do not understand; the meaning of the dream has escaped you and it is right for me to explain. You say that the dream said that I would die by the point of an iron weapon. But what sort of hands does a boar have? And what sort of iron point that you fear? For if it said that I would die by a tusk or tooth or some other appropriate attribute, you should do what you are doing. But as it is, the instrument is a weapon's point; and so then let me go since the fight is not against men." (39.1–40) 150

Croesus answered: "My child, you have won me over with your interpretation of the dream; and so since I have been won over by you I reverse my decision and let you go to the hunt." (40–41.1)

After these words, Croesus sent for the Phrygian Adrastus; when he arrived, 160
he spoke as follows to him: "Adrastus, I did not reproach you when you were struck down by an ugly misfortune, I cleansed you, received you in my palace, and offered you every luxury. Now then since you owe me good services in exchange for those that I have done for you, I ask that you be a guardian of my boy while he hastens out to the hunt, in case some malicious robbers turn up on the journey to do you harm. Furthermore, you should go where you will become famous for your deeds, for it is your hereditary duty and you have the strength and prowess besides." (41.1–42.1)

Adrastus answered: "Ordinarily I would not go out to this kind of contest, for it is not fitting that one under such a misfortune as mine associate with com- 170
panions who are faring well, nor do I have the desire and I should hold myself back for many reasons. But now, since you urge me and I must gratify you (for I owe you a return for your good services), I am ready to do this; expect that your boy, whom you order me to guard, will come back home to you unharmed because of his guardian." (42.1–43.1)

This was the nature of his answer to Croesus, and afterward they left equipped with a band of picked young men and dogs. When they came to the mountain Olympus, they hunted the wild beast, and after they had found him they stood in a circle round about and hurled their weapons. Then the 180
stranger, the guest and friend who had been cleansed of murder, who was called Adrastus, hurled his javelin at the boar, but missed him, and hit the son of Croesus, who, struck by the point of the weapon, fulfilled the prediction of the dream; someone ran to Croesus, as a messenger of what had happened, and when he came to Sardis he told him of the battle and the fate of his child. (43.1–44.1)

Croesus was greatly distressed by the death of his son and was even more disturbed because the very one whom he himself had purified had killed him. Overcome by his misfortune, Croesus called terribly on Zeus the Purifier, in- 190
voking him to witness that he had suffered at the hands of the stranger and guest-friend; he called on him too as god of the hearth and as god of friendship, giving this same god these different names: god of the hearth because he did not realize that he received in his palace and nourished as a guest the murderer of his son, and god of friendship because he sent him along as a guardian and found him to be his greatest enemy. (44.1–45.1)

Afterward the Lydians arrived with the corpse and the murderer followed behind. He stood before the dead body and stretching forth his hands surren- 200
dered himself to Croesus; he bade Croesus slaughter him over the corpse, telling of his former misfortune and how in addition to it he had destroyed the one who had cleansed him, and life for him was not worth living. Croesus heard and took pity on Adrastus, although he was enmeshed in so great a personal evil, and he spoke to him: "I have complete justice from yourself, my guest and friend, since you condemn yourself to death. You are not the one responsible for this evil (except insofar as you did the deed unwillingly), but some one of the gods somewhere who warned me previously of the things that were going to be." (45.1–45.3)

Croesus now buried his son as was fitting; and Adrastus, the son of Gordias, the son of Midas, this murderer of his own brother and murderer of the one who purified him, when the people had gone and quietness settled around the grave, conscious that he was the most oppressed by misfortune of mankind, slaughtered himself on the tomb. (45.3) 210

Croesus' personal and domestic tragedy was compounded by his political downfall. Daily the power of **Cyrus the Great** and the Persians was growing; and as they extended their empire to the west, Croesus' own kingdom of Lydia eventually was absorbed. In this crisis, Croesus consulted various oracles and came to believe that the one of Apollo at Delphi alone could speak the truth. He sent magnificent offerings to Delphi and inquired of the oracle whether or not he should go to war with the Persians. The Delphic reply is perhaps the most famous oracle of all time, typically ironic in its simple ambiguity: if Croesus attacked the Persians, he would destroy a mighty empire. Croesus, of course, thought he would destroy the empire of the Persians; instead he brought an end to his own. Through Croesus' suffering, the wisdom of Solon was confirmed. Herodotus tells of the fall of **Sardis** (the capital of Lydia) and the fate of Croesus, its king, and his other son, "a fine boy except that he could not speak" (1. 85.3–88.1):



Audio

THE DEFEAT OF CROESUS BY CYRUS THE GREAT

When the city was taken, one of the Persians made for Croesus to kill him, not knowing who he was; now Croesus saw the man coming, but he did not care, since in the present misfortune it made no difference to him if he were struck down and died. But the boy, this one who was mute, when he saw the Persian attacking, through fear of the terrible evil that was to happen broke into speech and cried: "Soldier, do not kill Croesus." This was the first time that he had uttered a sound, but afterward he could speak for the rest of his life. (85.3–85.4)

The Persians then held Sardis and took Croesus himself captive after he had ruled for fourteen years and been besieged for fourteen days, and as the oracle predicted, he brought to an end his own mighty empire. The Persians took Croesus and led him to Cyrus, who had a great pyre erected and ordered Croesus bound in fetters to mount it and along with him twice seven children of the Lydians. Cyrus intended either to offer them as the first fruits of the booty to some one of the gods, perhaps in a desire to fulfill a vow, or having learned that Croesus was a god-fearing man placed him on the pyre, wishing to see if any of the gods would save him from being burned alive. At any rate this is what Cyrus did, but to Croesus as he stood on the pyre came the realization (even though he was in such sore distress) that the words of Solon had been spoken under god's inspiration: "No one of the living is happy!" (86.1–86.3) 10

As this occurred to him, he sighed and groaned and broke the lengthy silence by calling out three times the name of Solon. When Cyrus heard this, he bade interpreters ask Croesus who this was whom he invoked, and they came up and asked the question. For a time Croesus did not answer, but eventually through compulsion he said: "The man I should like at all costs to converse with every tyrant." (86.3–86.4)

Since his words were unintelligible to them, they asked again and again what he meant; annoyed by their persistence, he told how Solon the Athenian first

came to him, and after having beheld all his prosperity made light of it by the nature of his talk, and how everything turned out for him just as Solon had predicted, with words that had no more reference to Croesus himself than to all human beings and especially those who in their own estimation considered themselves to be happy. As Croesus talked, the fire was kindled and began to burn the outer edges of the pyre. (86.4–86.6) 30

When Cyrus heard from his interpreters what Croesus had said, he changed his mind, reflecting that he, too, was a human being who was surrendering another human being while still alive to the fire; besides he feared retribution, and realizing how nothing in human affairs is certain and secure, he ordered the burning fire to be quenched as quickly as possible and Croesus and those with him taken down from the pyre. And they made the attempt but were unable to master the flames. (86.6–87.1) 40

Then, according to the Lydian version of the story, when Croesus learned of Cyrus' change of heart as he saw all the men trying to put out the fire but no longer able to hold it in check, he shouted aloud calling on Apollo, if ever he had received from him any gift that was pleasing, to stand by him and save him from the present evil. In tears he called on the god, and suddenly out of the clear and calm atmosphere storm clouds rushed together, burst forth in violent torrents of rain, and quenched the fire. (87.1–87.2)

Thus Cyrus knew that Croesus was beloved by god and a good man. He brought him down from the pyre and asked: "Croesus, what man persuaded you to march against my land and become my enemy instead of my friend?" And he answered: "O king, these things I have done are to your good fortune but my own misfortune. The god of the Hellenes is responsible since he incited me to war. For no one is so senseless as to prefer war instead of peace. In time of peace sons bury their fathers, but in war fathers bury their sons. But it was somehow the pleasure of the gods that this be so." These were his words, and Cyrus released him and sat by his side and held him in great respect, and both he and all those around him looked on him with wonder. (87.2–88.1) 50

Thus Croesus became the wise and benevolent counselor of Cyrus. In the concluding pages of Herodotus' *minisaga*, Croesus sends to inquire of the priestess of Apollo why the oracle had misled him. "It is impossible even for god to escape destined fate," the priestess replies and then tells of the ways in which Apollo indeed tried to ameliorate Croesus' fated misfortune (91.1).

Apollo saved him from burning. And it was not right that Croesus find fault with the oracle that he received. For Apollo warned that if he marched against Persia he would destroy a great empire. He should, if he were going to act wisely with respect to this reply, have sent again to ask whether his own empire or that of Cyrus was meant. If he did not understand the reply and he did not press the question, he should see himself as the one to blame. . . . When he [Croesus] heard, he agreed that it was his own fault and not that of the god. (91.3–91.6)

The story of Croesus was also narrated in a poem by the lyric poet Bacchylides of Ceos, written in 468. In this version, Croesus himself ordered the pyre to be lit, but Zeus extinguished the fire and Apollo took Croesus to live happily forever among the Hyperboreans as a reward for his piety.

Herodotus as Myth Historian

The Herodotean account gives us a glimpse into the fascinating world of legendary history. How can one possibly with complete confidence isolate the facts from the fiction in the epic context of Herodotus' literary art? The name of Croesus' son Atys means "the one under the influence of Ate" (a goddess of doom and destruction), and he has links, too, in cult and in story, with Attis and Adonis. Adrastus may be connected to the mythological concept of Nemesis orAdrasteia (Necessity), and the name Adrastus can be translated as "the one who cannot escape," that is, "the one who is doomed." Incidents in the tale recall those of the legendary Calydonian boar hunt. Is there anyone today who has enough faith in miracles to believe that Apollo saved Croesus from a fiery death?

Yet there *are* parts of the myth that perhaps may be true. Despite chronological problems, Solon could have met Croesus, although not at the time Herodotus imagines.¹⁰ Croesus may have had a son who died young. But the mythographer and historian Herodotus could never be satisfied with this prosaic truth alone. His stories (wrought with exquisite art) must illustrate a different level of emotional and spiritual truth that illuminates character and elucidates philosophy. The life of Tellus the Athenian, the happiest of men, reveals the character and the values of those Greeks who fought and won in great battles like that of Marathon, defending their country against the Persian invaders in the first quarter of the fifth century B.C.; god will punish their king Xerxes for his sinful hubris, just as he did Croesus, Xerxes' prototype. Herodotus explains through his manipulation of traditional tales (military numbers, strategy, and "facts" will come later) why the Greeks defeated the Persians. These are truths, too, but of another order, and they are the essence of mythic art.

Greek Religion

Our description of the nature of the gods revealed in their mythology and its religious and philosophical ramifications leads inevitably to further consideration (necessarily brief) of the vast and complex subject of Greek religion. It is essential to devote some attention to the role that religion played in the lives of the ancient Greeks and the way that myth and religion converged to give meaning to their world and to establish their proper relationship with the divine. Greek religious observance developed over hundreds of years molded by many diverse influences: the survival of beliefs from their Indo-European forebears, the heritage of Minoan-Mycenaean ideas and practices, the legacy of Near Eastern contact.

Greek Mythology and Religion

Our understanding of the interrelation between Greek mythology and religion has evolved over a long period of time. **Up to the end of the nineteenth century, it was assumed that Greek myths presented a largely untrammelled view of ancient religious thought, whether through literal or philosophical and allegorical interpretation.** Indeed, similar interpretations can be traced back to antiquity itself. **By the end of the nineteenth century, scholarly opinion came to recognize**

Other Legendary Folktales in Herodotus: Gyges, Arion, and Polycrates

There are many other important and entertaining mythical legends, with folktale motifs, in Herodotus' *History*. Although the choice is difficult, we single out three other examples.

Candaules, king of Lydia, continually boasted that his wife was the most beautiful woman in the world. He wanted to convince his favorite bodyguard, Gyges, that this claim was no exaggeration, and so he arranged that Gyges should see his wife naked, without her knowledge. She, however, became aware of the great insult (it is most shameful among the Lydians for even a man to be seen naked). In revenge, she plotted with Gyges, who was forced to kill Candaules and win the throne and the queen for himself (1. 10–13).

Herodotus tells the story of the musician Arion of Lesbos. He had traveled around Greece and the Greek cities of Italy teaching the ritual of Dionysus, particularly the singing of the dithyramb, the sacred choral song performed in honor of the god. He was particularly favored by Periander, tyrant of Corinth, and he decided to return to Greece from Italy in a Corinthian ship. Plotting to steal the money Arion had gained from his performances in Italy, the sailors threw him overboard, allowing him first to give a final performance standing on the stern of the ship. When he jumped into the sea, a dolphin saved him and carried him on its back to the sanctuary of Poseidon at Cape Taenarum (the southern cape of the Peloponnese). From there he made his way back to Corinth, where he told Periander what had happened and appeared at Periander's behest to confound the sailors when they told him that Arion was safe in Italy (1. 23–24).

Periander was a historical figure who ruled over Corinth around 600 B.C., and Arion was perhaps also historical. He was credited with the invention of the dithyramb. Dionysus is associated with dolphins in the myth of the sailors narrated in the seventh *Homeric Hymn* (see pp. 323–324), and Herodotus tells how there was a statue of a man on a dolphin (said to have been dedicated by Arion himself) in the temple of Poseidon at Taenarum. Thus, the story of Arion is undoubtedly connected with the worship of Poseidon and Dionysus.

Finally, an episode in the life of Polycrates, tyrant of Samos, echoes dramatically the Herodotean philosophy found in the legend of Solon and Croesus. Polycrates, like Croesus, continued to attain vast wealth and great power. His friend, King Amasis of Egypt, expressed troubled concern to Polycrates that his unbridled successes might eventually lead to disaster, since divinity is jealous of prosperity untempered by misfortune. He advised the tyrant to cast far away his most valued and prized possession, so that it might never appear again among human beings. Polycrates chose a beloved work of art, a precious gold ring with an emerald. He himself in a boat threw it way out into the sea and went home to weep at his loss. Five or six days later, a fisherman came proudly to the palace and presented to the tyrant a magnificent fish that he had caught. As the fish was being prepared for dinner, the ring of Polycrates was found in its belly. When Amasis learned what had happened to Polycrates, he realized that one cannot help another avoid what is fated and that Polycrates' life would not end well because he had found what he had tried to cast away forever. Indeed, Polycrates ultimately was murdered by a villainous Persian named Oroetes (3. 39–40ff).

For translations of Herodotus' stories about Gyges, Arion, and Polycrates, see www.oup.com/us/morford.

the inadequacy of this approach, and with the rise of modern archaeology, attention shifted to the role of religious ritual and practice as the most fruitful focus of inquiry for understanding ancient Greek religion. What the Greeks actually did in the performance of their worship began to overshadow the significance of the myths they told about their gods. The ability of myths to reveal anything about ancient Greek religious ideas came into serious question. By the beginning of the twenty-first century, the situation had shifted to a much less narrow and dogmatic position. This new appreciation for how Greek myth interacted with ancient Greek religious ideas and practice has become subtler, more complex, and much more sensitive to the interplay of cultural elements within society as a whole through the influence of anthropology and cross-cultural studies, which examine the relationship between myth and religion within societies, both ancient and modern, and through the development of sophisticated literary theories that offer more varied and perhaps more fruitful strategies for teasing out religious symbol and metaphor from literary texts. Jean-Pierre Vernant has eloquently written about this contemporary integration of myth, ritual, and artistic representation.

Apart from reverential awe and a diffused feeling of the divine, the Greek religion presents itself as a vast symbolic construction, complex and coherent, that allows room for thought, as well as feeling, on all levels and in all aspects, including the cult. Myth played its part in this system in the same way as ritual practices and representations of the divine. Indeed, myth, rite, and figurative portrayals were the three modes of expression—verbal, gestural, and iconic—by which the Greeks manifested their religious experience. Each constituted a specific language that, even in its association with the two others, responded to particular needs and functioned autonomously.¹¹

We may imagine such an integration of myth, ritual, and image, if we consider the religious experience at the Panathenaic festival, celebrated annually to honor Athena Polias, guardian of the city of Athens (see pp. 179–180). The festival would include most of the populace of Athens in procession. The community would ceremonially move through the city toward the Acropolis. The participants would be organized in terms of the various groupings into which the polis was divided, all citizens having their own place, performing their special functions in the ceremony. The central moment of the festival would be the presentation of the ceremonial robe (*peplos*) to deck the old, wooden, cult image of Athena. Women of Athens wove the garment anew each year, but it was always embroidered with the same mythic scene, the Gigantomachy. After the presentation, there would be a sacrifice of hecatombs (a hecatomb was a sacrifice of a hundred cattle), and the meat was divided among the populace. Poets would have written hymns to be sung, which reiterated and perhaps reinterpreted the mythic tradition passed down from generation to generation. The citizens, gathered together, would be able to see upon Athena's temple, the Parthenon, artistic treatments of many stories from myth and legend: in the pediments, Athena's birth fully grown from the head of Zeus, her father, and the contest she had with Poseidon over the right to be accorded special worship in the city of Athens; on the Ionic frieze, the celebration of the Panathenaea itself, immortalized in stone. The presentation of the robe would serve to underscore that precise and explicit anthropomorphism

that characterized the Greek conception of deity. In the convergence of myth, art, and ritual, the religious experience would make the multifarious world intelligible: the procession from the periphery of the city to its heart uniting the participants spatially, socially, and politically, orienting the Athenians to their land; the retelling of their myths and traditions, defining them in relation to their gods and their heroic past; the performance of sacrifices and ritual offerings, establishing the boundaries between human and god, human and animal, and living and dead.

The Nature of Greek Religion

It is customary to begin a discussion of Greek religion by asserting that the ancient Greeks as a people possessed **no closed priestly caste, no unifying doctrinal creed, no religiously authoritative book or canon that transmitted the essence of one faith, and no fixed and unchanging rite or ritual that was everywhere observed**. Though perhaps such generalizations are to some extent true, they are extremely misleading. It is more reasonable and accurate to speak of **a shared religious viewpoint, a common religious experience** that we can intelligibly conceptualize under the heading of Greek religion. The reasons for this are many and varied, but **the importance of the epic tradition for establishing a shared identity cannot be overstated**. The identification of the gods (their names and appearance, their relationships, characteristics, and powers, with Zeus as supreme) and the elaboration of the genesis of the world of immortals and mortals that was established by Homer and Hesiod became fundamental and pervasive. Here was a fertile reservoir of mythology and legend for the development of religious ideas, affirmations, and practices that were passed down and enhanced by tradition, prized as a common possession that defined what it meant to be Greek, as much as did the acceptance of a common language.

There were, to be sure, **a plethora of different religious rituals and festivals, a multitude of variations on mythical tales, and a profusion of artistic representations of divinity** among the hundreds of city-states that existed from the development of the polis in the tenth century B.C. to the end of pagan worship in the Late Roman Empire. **Different communities would devote their principal worship to different gods**. At Athens preeminent was Athena, at Argos Hera, and at Ephesus Artemis. Communities would not neglect the other gods in the pantheon, but by their choice of a special patron deity, they would signify their unique relationship with the world beyond the mortal realm. Sometimes even the “pantheon” of gods would itself shift and mutate from polis to polis, with certain gods included and others excluded. In addition, each god could hold within the same community a variety of epithets, could be seen in diverse roles, and could be honored with different rituals. Upon this creative multiplicity, **the epic tradition worked as a restraint and set limits on this profusion of belief, expression, and practice, and over time, as might be expected, it imposed a certain homogeneity of religious experience, a familiar and unifying religious landscape beyond the separate and diverse manifestations of religious worship in the individual polis**. The **decline of the importance of the polis** in the fourth century B.C. would have a similar effect. **As the Greeks came less and less to identify their uniqueness in terms of the local polis to which they belonged, they appropriated a more cosmopolitan and homogeneous viewpoint**.

The Civic Religion of the Polis

The Greeks had many words to express the “sacred,” or “holy,” or “pious,” but no single word that would encompass what we generally mean by “religion,” no single term that would take in the broad canvas of beliefs and practices that they associated with worship of their gods. Like all religions, Greek religion had an eminently social function. Nevertheless, it is difficult today to appreciate how deeply ingrained religion was in all facets of ancient life, especially those that we might consider “secular.” In fact the Greeks would not have understood such a dichotomy. The power of the sacred permeated almost every aspect of ancient communal life in a Greek city-state. The polis became the center of the Greeks’ conception of their identity; it ordered their life socially, politically, militarily, economically, culturally, and, most importantly for our survey, religiously.

By the sixth century, the main elements of Greek religion (reflected in the epics of Homer and Hesiod) had been set, though diverse developments would continue, as described here. Public, civic worship of the gods would remain the most distinctive feature of religious life in the polis. Let us look at civic worship in Athens as a typical example, since it is so important and so well documented. The Acropolis, with its beautiful buildings and monuments (especially the Parthenon and Erechtheum), was the religious heart of the city. Yet, throughout every part of the community there were temples, sanctuaries, and shrines, some dedicated to the state gods, some to the more localized gods and numinous powers of neighborhoods and homes.

Athenian life, both public and private, was organized around the religious calendar, based on a lunar year, and the most sacred day was at the beginning of the new lunar cycle. Nearly half of the calendar year was devoted to *heortai* (sing., *heorte*), the general Greek term for “festival,” derived from the Greek word for “banquet,” denoting its primary pleasure. Festivals could take place at the state level or at a much more localized level in various areas or neighborhoods of the city. The first month of the Attic year was named *Hecatombaion*, during which the *Hecatombaia* (Festival of One Hundred Sacrifices) was held in honor of Apollo. The *Panathenaea* was also celebrated during this month, and because of its splendor in honor of Athena, the patron goddess of the city, it was appropriately considered the principal festival of the new year (see above).

During the month of *Anthesterion*, the Athenians celebrated the *Anthesteria*. It was the principal spring festival in honor of Dionysus, and for three days it celebrated the opening of the new wine. It was an occasion for great joy, with masked performers entertaining the populace, but it also encompassed darker aspects. Some of the rituals of the *Anthesteria* were meant to recall a number of unsettling myths: Orestes’ arrival in Athens after he had killed his mother (see pp. 443–447), the killing and dismemberment of Dionysus (see p. 322), and the legend of Icarius and his daughter Erigone (see p. 322). In much the same way as an Easter celebration, it incorporated elements of death and rebirth.

Two other festivals of importance are discussed in later chapters: the *Brauronia* in honor of Artemis (see p. 230) and the *Thesmophoria* (see p. 350), a women’s festival in honor of Demeter, immortalized in Aristophanes’ comedy *Thesmophoriazusae*.

Countless festivals were celebrated throughout the year. It has been estimated that **some 2,000 cults** existed in Attica alone, with about 170 annual festival days in its sacred calendar.

Nowhere is it more evident that **for the Greeks the boundary between the religious and the secular was blurred than in the following festivals: the Great Dionysia was established in the sixth century B.C. in Athens**, and it was amid the ritual celebrations of this festival that select poets of the city would perform their tragedies and comedies in honor of the god Dionysus; **the great Panhellenic festivals, the most famous being at Olympia (in honor of Zeus) and Delphi (in honor of Apollo), included athletic contests amid the religious celebrations.**

Heroic Cults of the Dead

In addition to festivals that honored the principal gods of the city, each polis reserved special occasions to honor their great heroes, who were virtually given a divine status after their deaths (see p. 137). **The varied, chthonic nature of rituals in heroic cults was meant to differentiate them from the worship of the Olympian gods.** For example, in a sacrifice to a chthonic power, the animal's blood was generally not splashed upon the altar but was caught in a pit or poured upon the ground. **The animal chosen would more likely be darker in color.** The heroes of a community represented more localized traditions and cults. Heroes were like the gods in that they had power to act for good or ill from beyond the grave, especially in favor of the polis where they were honored. Unlike the gods, however, heroes were not immortal and in death lived in the realm of Hades or the Fields of the Blessed.

Two famous legendary heroes honored by chthonic cults were King Oedipus and the seer Amphiaraus (both from the city of Thebes), who lived extraordinary lives, died mysteriously, and were worshiped as divine. For their legends, see pp. 414–423 and 428.

Priests and Priestesses

Priests belonged to the most important category of religious officials, among many others who were concerned with the performance of rites, especially sacrifice **(though generally speaking, anyone could perform a sacrifice)**, the upkeep of temples and sanctuaries, and the management of accounts. Since civic and religious activities were usually so closely linked, civil magistrates could also be involved, especially in connection with the celebration of the festivals.

Although they represented no official caste or hierarchy and theoretically anyone could officiate at a religious ritual, **priests could be elected or appointed by lot and some priesthoods were offered for sale.** **Others served because of their birth.** The observance of the traditions of a particular rite was all that was required, and this was learned by prior participation. The length of service varied considerably, but records show that some served for a very long time. **The priesthood for the Eleusinian Mysteries was held by only two Athenian families (the Kerkydes and the Eumolpidae) from archaic times throughout its history.** Different priesthoods imposed different requirements and rules about marriage or virginity, sexual abstinence, diet, and so on.

It was not a calling that required the devotion of one's entire life, though it could carry great prestige. Important priests were given particular respect because of their special dress and imposing appearance and behavior in the performance of dramatic major rites and rituals and in religious processions. They also were honored by impressive statues of themselves and memorable reliefs on tombstones.

The role of the priestess was also very important, as revealed in the book *Portrait of a Priestess: Women and Ritual in Ancient Greece*, by Joan Breton Connelly. This is required reading for anyone wishing to pursue serious study of both Greek religion and the position of women in antiquity because of Connelly's scrupulous interpretation of a vast amount of evidence ranging from the Archaic through Hellenistic periods and even into Roman imperial times. Even though much of this evidence is fragmentary, elusive, and ambiguous, Connelly is generally able to reconstruct a credible, substantive account embracing "eligibility and acquisition of office, costume and attributes, representations, responsibilities, ritual actions, compensation for service, authority and privileges, and the commemoration of priestesses in death." Her discussion includes not only the life of priestesses but also the religious life of girls, maidens, and women generally, and one of her central themes is "the correlation between domestic ritual, in the care of the house, and public ritual, in the care of the temple." Religion was "the one area in which Greek women assumed roles equal and comparable to those of men." Many of the requirements imposed on priestesses were similar to those imposed on priests—for example, length of service, rules of behavior, and eligibility.

Of particular value is Connelly's concentration on four prominent priesthoods for which there is the most evidence: Athena Polias of Athens; Demeter and Kore (Persephone) at Eleusis; Hera at Argos; and Apollo at Delphi. Her conclusion should carry special weight for the student of religion:

For Christianity to truly separate itself from "pagan" cult worship it had to abolish one of the most visible and characteristic pillars of Greek religion, the sacred service of women, maidens, and girls. . . . In A.D. 503, the emperor Theodosius issued an edict that called not only for the destruction of all temples and images, but also for the cessation of age-old festivals, including the Eleusinian Mysteries, the Panathenaia, and the Olympic Games. With this came the elimination of sacred office and the priestesses who had served the Greek cults for more than a millennium.¹²

Priestesses tended to have a greater role in cults of female divinities than male divinities, but the relationship between the office of the priest and the official roles of the priestess needs clarification, insofar as the meager, difficult, and controversial evidence may allow.

Seers

A seer was a prophet whose profession was to recognize and interpret signs that were elicited through sacrifice or occurred as a result of unusual portents, which his audience believed were sent explicitly by the gods to inform them about matters of every sort, personal, political, military, financial, and religious. Historical seers wisely modeled themselves on the performances and techniques of legendary ones, such as Calchas, Melampus, and Tiresias, whose pronouncements

always came true. Therefore, it was imperative that they perfect their charismatic skills for success in a career that must have been highly competitive.

A successful seer would be much in demand and could earn a great deal of money by traveling extensively to provide personal services to an eager public that would then not have to undergo the inconvenience and expense incurred by a trip to a distant oracular site, such as Delphi. The names of only about seventy historical seers have survived; some female seers (similar to the males) have been identified and are to be distinguished from oracular priestesses, such as the Pythia, the oracular prophetess at Delphi.

The seer's repertoire involved various types of augury, for example, the interpretation of the flight and cries of birds, the behavior of serpents, the content of dreams, and natural portents such as lightning and thunder, earthquakes, and eclipses. In general, it encompassed any occurrence that was sudden and could not be controlled and required explanation. In Homer (*Iliad*, 1.69), the seer Calchas is judged to be the best of bird interpreters by far.

Sacrificial animals were examined for marks and abnormalities that might be signs of divine communication. Prophets would scrutinize the entrails of an animal most intently (extispicy), especially the liver (hepatoscopy). Certain seers could become possessed by the god in the performance of their prophetic skills.

Michael Attyah Flower, in his study *The Seer in Ancient Greece*, concludes:

[W]ithout divination Greek "religion" itself would have been fundamentally altered, since divination was an integral part of a whole nexus of relationships, rituals, and beliefs that comprised the religious system of the Greeks.¹³

Mystery Religions

A major religious theme (especially in Part One) and one inextricably bound to the study of mythology concentrates on the vital subject of Mystery Religions, which differ in important respects from the civic religious ceremonies discussed earlier. The important Mysteries (among many) were celebrated in honor of Dionysus, Demeter, and Orpheus, and are treated in their respective chapters. Chapter 15, which deals with the Realm of Hades, with a description of its Elysium and Tartarus, highlights the fundamental religious tenets essential to Mystery Cults: the existence of a soul, the conflict between good and evil, and reward and punishment in the afterlife.

The dogmas on which these religions were based were very different in character and spirit from those of the traditional worship of the Olympians. Whereas the public cults did not demand rigid adherence to a religious dogma, the Mysteries required acceptance of specific doctrine. Sacred texts, written or orally transmitted, laid down the rules for ritual practice and moral behavior. Denial of the divinity of Dionysus, for example, led to disastrous consequences. Those who dared to deny that Zeus was his father, but instead believed that his mortal mother Semele had lied and become pregnant by a mortal and not the god, suffered divine retribution. Rituals in the Eleusinian mysteries were ordained by the goddess Demeter herself for those who wanted to be initiated in order to find redemption, immortality, and joy. A more comprehensive summary of these cults may be found in Chapter 16.

The Sacrifice

The most significant religious act in Greek ritual was the sacrifice. Sacrifices were held at the major festivals that punctuated the religious calendar, as well as at the myriad occasions, both public and private, when the favor of the gods was needed: at the establishment of a colony, at the beginning of a war, at the negotiation of a truce, when an oracle was consulted, when a marriage was celebrated, and so on. The evidence for the elements or stages of the sacrificial ritual comes from the literary record and archaeological remains. The ritual developed over hundreds of years, and local variations existed in every city and sanctuary. There were, however, **typical features. Homer is our earliest source;** his detailed description indicates the main elements required to conduct a proper sacrifice. **Nestor, the king of Pylos,** has ordered that a sacrifice be offered to Athena (*Odyssey* 3. 430–463):

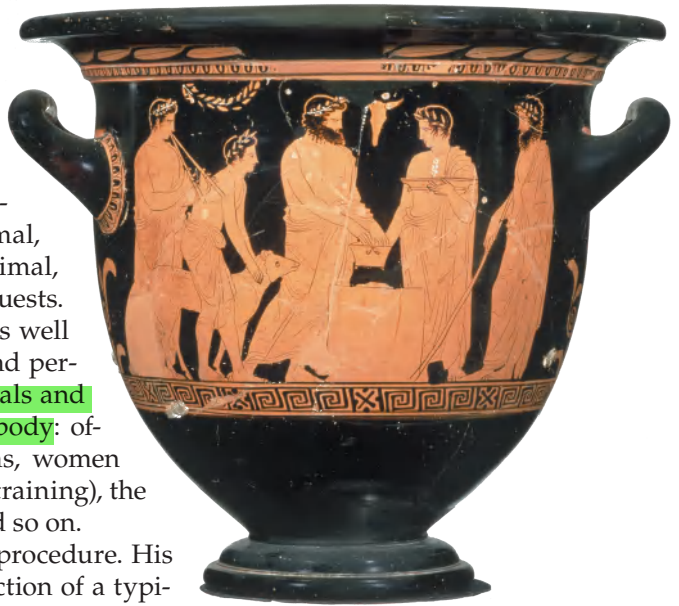
Everyone hastened to the task. The cow came from the fields; from the well-balanced ship came the comrades of great-hearted Telemachus; the smith came too with his implements of bronze, the tools of his craft, anvil, and hammer, and well-made tongs, and with these he worked the gold. And Athena came to meet the sacrifice. Nestor, the aged chariot-driver, supplied the gold, which the smith then worked and gilded the horns of the heifer, so that Athena might take delight as she looked upon the offering. Stratios and noble Echephron led the animal by the horns. Aretus came from the storeroom and brought lustral water in a basin adorned with flowers. In his other hand he held a basket of barley-grains. Thrasymedes, steadfast in battle, held a sharp ax and took his position nearby to fell the animal with a blow. Perseus held the bowl that was to receive the blood. Nestor, the aged chariot-driver, began the rite with the ritual purification of the hands and the sprinkling of the barley-groats. He prayed earnestly to Athena, beginning the sacrifice by throwing tufts of hair from the animal's head into the fire. Now when they had prayed and thrown the barley-grains, straightaway Nestor's son, high-spirited Thasymedes, standing nearby struck the blow. The ax cut through the tendons of the neck and loosened the strength of the heifer. The women delivered the shrill cry: daughters, daughters-in-law, and the noble wife of Nestor, Eurydice, eldest of the daughters of Clymenus. The men lifted the animal up and held it aloft over the much-traveled earth. Then Peisistratus, best of men, cut its throat. When its black blood had streamed out and its life had left its bones, straightaway they cut the animal up, quickly cut out the thigh bones all in proper fashion, wrapped them round in folds of fat and placed upon them pieces of meat. The old man burned them over a wood fire and poured upon them sparkling wine. Near him the young men held in their hands five-pronged roasting forks. Now after the thigh bones were burned and the inner organs tasted, they cut the rest into pieces and put them on spits and roasted them, holding the pointed spits in their hands . . . and when they had roasted the outer meat and drawn it off the spits, they sat down and had a feast. Noble men waited on them, pouring wine into golden goblets.

The day of a major sacrificial ceremony was one of religious solemnity, celebration, and rejoicing. Typically, **the officiators at the sacrifice would wear white**

clothes and garland themselves. The animal too, as here, was decked out splendidly. The community as a whole (men and women, old and young) took part, and in a very real sense the sacrifice gave cohesion to the community; it established and sanctified the community and defined who might rightly participate. Certain participants were assigned roles with responsibilities: leading the animal, bringing the basin, providing the ax, felling the animal, cutting up and roasting the parts, and serving the guests. Over time, the further development of the polis, as well as the inherent nature of the sacrifice as drama and performance, fostered a greater elaboration of the rituals and the proliferation of roles assumed by the citizen body: officiating priests, inner-circle attendants, musicians, women carrying baskets, ephebes (young men in military training), the animal herders, political and religious officials, and so on.

Homer gives the essential details of sacrificial procedure. His account is fundamentally important for reconstruction of a typical sacrifice in the classical period. Cattle were the most precious, as well as most prestigious, offering. Since they were the most expensive, they would be used only on special occasions. Sheep were the most common, but goats and pigs and poultry were often used as well. Other animals, like fish, are much rarer. More atypical kinds of sacrifices are attested—for example, the horse-drowning sacrifices in honor of Poseidon. The sex of the animal generally, though by no means always, corresponded to the sex of the divinity honored or propitiated. The animal must be unblemished to serve as a fit offering to the deity. A prominent feature of sacrifice was the fiction that the animal must be a willing victim of the slaughter. Sacrifice specifically included sprinkling the animal with water, which caused it to shake its head as if giving its consent. The presence of water was chiefly for the purification of the participants as an outward sign to god and to the others that those in attendance were clean and pure and rightly present. This ritual action, as a rule, opened the rite of the sacrifice; the use of it is often described as a beginning.

The animal was brought within the sacred precinct of the god or goddess, called the *temenos* (from the Greek word “to cut”) because it has been sanctified, “cut” off from the ordinary, profane world. Then amid much pomp and procession (music was invariably part of the ritual) the animal was led to the altar. The altar typically stood outdoors in front of the temple. For the animal to balk, as we have said, would have been considered a bad omen. At this point, there was the ceremonial washing of hands by the officiators; at this time, water was sprinkled over the animal, as we have said, to assure its consent. A young maid came forward with a basket on her head and within the basket was the knife, which was covered by the barley grains or barley cakes. The participants would take out handfuls of the grain, and after the priest had uttered a prayer, everyone would throw the grain upon the altar and animal. The priest would remove the knife from the basket and cut tufts of hair from the animal. This was a sign that the animal was no longer inviolable and could fittingly be killed. The hair itself was offered on the flames as an introductory sacrifice.



Preparation for Sacrifice.

Red-figure krater, attributed to the Kleophon painter or his school, ca. 425 B.C.; height: 42.3 cm. The scene depicts a ram led to the sacrifice. In the center is the altar, splashed with blood. The older, bearded male near the altar officiates. He is washing his hands, perhaps in preparation to sprinkle the animal to assure its consent. The young man opposite him holds the water basin and the *kanoun* (a sacrificial basket to carry grain offerings or other necessary items). Between the two is a *bukranion* (bull skull), a common motif in sacrificial ritual. On the left are an *auletes* (flute player) and a youth leading the animal. To the right another bearded male stands, perhaps another priest or attendant. (© Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)



A Sacrifice to Apollo. Red-figure Attic krater, ca. 430 B.C.; height: 33 cm. The vase presents a typical scene after the killing of the sacrificial animal. Parts of the carcass have been cut up and roasted on spits. The altar stands in the center, with logs laid on top for the fire. On the far right stands Apollo, to whom the sacrifice is offered, in which he partakes in some way. He holds a laurel branch. A laurel tree also stands behind the altar. The older, bearded male near the altar officiates. What he is holding is uncertain; it has been identified as one of the internal organs, perhaps the heart. On either side of him are two youths. The one on the left is roasting the *splanchna* (internal organs) on spits held over the fire on the altar. These were cut up, divided among the participants, and eaten immediately. The youth on the right holds in his right hand an *oinochoe* (wine jug) and in his left a *kanoun* (sacrificial basket). (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY/© Artres)

The larger sacrificial animals would have been given a first, stunning blow with the ax. Smaller animals would be lifted over the altar and have their throat cut. The women would wail the ritual cry (*ololuge*), which was probably understood as expressing joy, an emotional release at the climax of the drama of death. After the stunning blow, the victim was lifted over the altar, so that its neck could be cut. A basin was ready to catch the blood, which was splashed on the altar. The animal was then butchered. The bones, especially the thighbones, were removed and wrapped in fat and topped with pieces of flesh, to be burned for the god, in the belief that the gods derived pleasure from the savor of the burned fat and thighbones. After the burning of the thighbones, the internal organs (*splanchna*) were then spitted, roasted, and eaten by the most important members of the assembly. Wine was poured over the fire, and the roasting for the main meal began. Just what pleasure the gods received from sacrifice was a topic that aroused a great deal of speculation and at times unease among the Greeks. Hesiod's aetiological tale in the *Theogony* (see pp. 91–92) of Prometheus'

unsuccessful deception of Zeus is a resolution of the problem. Hesiod validates the reality that human beings received the best part of the sacrifice. In fact, the sacrifice provided one of the main opportunities for the eating of meat. After the meal, any meat remaining was distributed and taken home by the participants. The skin belonged to the sanctuary, or, as at Athens, it was sold and the money deposited in the city treasury.

Since antiquity, a great deal of scholarly debate has arisen on the meaning, origin, and development of the sacrifice. In ancient times, Theophrastus (ca. 370–287 B.C.), Greek philosopher and successor of Aristotle, attributed three functions to the sacrifice: to honor the god, to give thanks for a blessing already received, and to persuade the god to grant a blessing in the future. Modern scholars offer various interpretations. Anthropologist Walter Burkert argues that many of the elements of the sacrificial ritual can be traced back to preagricultural hunting practices and that the principal reason for many features of the rite was to allay the fear and anxiety that primitive human beings supposedly felt at the killing of an animal. For Burkert, this was the purpose that lay behind the fiction of the animal's willingness to die. The main features included the shrill cry of the women at the moment of death; the concealment of the knife in the basket of grain; and the gathering of the bones, fat, and flesh in an attempt to reconstitute ritually the animal. Other scholars, for example, Jean-Pierre Vernant, prefer to interpret the meaning of the ritual strictly in terms of a festive celebration, the social and religious hierarchy and cohesion that it established among the participants and between man and god, or as the one vital and essential way to make the community "right" with the gods.

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See also the Select Bibliography at the end of Chapter 1 for related comparative studies.

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Bacchylides	<i>Ode</i> 3.15–62: Apollo and Croesus
Hyginus	<i>Fables (Fabulae)</i> 194: the story of Arion
Xenophon	<i>Cyropaedia</i> 7.2.9–7.2.29: Cyrus and Croesus

Notes

1. Nymphs are sometimes classified as follows: the spirits of waters, springs, lakes, and rivers are called Naiads; Potamiads are specifically the nymphs of rivers; tree-nymphs are generally called Dryads or Hamadryads, although their name means "spirits of oak trees" in particular; Meliae are the nymphs of ash trees.
2. The mortal parent may bask in the grand aura of the great mythological age of saga and boast of a genealogy that in the not too distant past included at least one divine ancestor.
3. Jack Miles, *God: A Biography* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1995), especially pp. 397–408.
4. Her name was Cydippe and she was a priestess of Hera, hence the necessity for her presence at the festival. The temple would be the Argive Heraeum.
5. Herodotus here uses the masculine article with the Greek word for god (not goddess), *ho theos*. He seems to be thinking of one supreme god or more abstractly of a divine power. Significantly, the mother does not refer to Hera specifically, although subsequently it is to the goddess Hera that she prays on behalf of her sons.
6. These statues have been excavated and do much to tantalize in the quest for precise distinctions between myth and history in Herodotus' account.
7. That is, human beings are entirely at the mercy of what befalls them.
8. The ritual entailed, at least partly, the slaying of a suckling pig and the pouring of the blood over the hands of the guilty murderer, who sat in silence at the hearth while Zeus was invoked as the Purifier.
9. These words of Croesus at first may strike the modern reader as extremely cruel, but he means only that he cannot consider the other boy, who is deaf and mute, as his son in the same way. We are told elsewhere that Croesus did everything for the unfortunate boy, but his hopes, both domestic and political, rested in Atys.

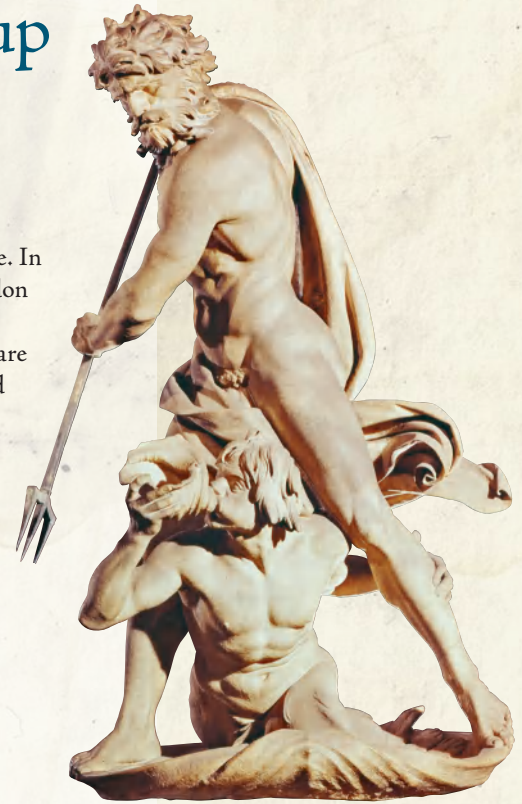
10. Solon held office in Athens as archon extraordinary in 594, and his travels took place at some time after that date; his death occurred in the years following 560. Croesus did not become king of Sardis until ca. 560, and he was defeated by Cyrus in 546.
11. J. P. Vernant, *Greek Religion in Religions of Antiquity* (New York: Collier Macmillan Publishers, 1989), p. 167.
12. Joan Breton Connelly, *Portrait of a Priestess: Women and Ritual in Ancient Greece* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2007), p. 279. The earlier quotations come from the Introduction, pp. 1–5.
13. Michael Attyah Flower, *The Seer in Ancient Greece* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2008), p. 245.

For a translation of Bacchylides, see
www.oup.com/us/morford.

Poseidon, Sea Deities, Group Divinities, and Monsters

By the harbor there is a temple of Poseidon and a freestanding statue of stone. In addition to the many names that have been fashioned by the poets for Poseidon as an adornment for their verses, and those names which custom has established for each particular community, the names of the god that all men use are Pelagaios, (God of the Sea), Asphaleios (God of Security), and Hippios (God of Horses).

—PAUSANIAS, *Description of Greece* 7.21.7



POSEIDON, BEST KNOWN AS the great god of waters in general and of the sea in particular, was by no means the first or only such divinity. As we have seen, Pontus (Sea) was produced by Ge in the initial stages of creation; and two of the Titans, **Oceanus** and Tethys, bore thousands of children, the **Oceanids**. In addition, Pontus mated with his mother, Ge, and begat (among other progeny, discussed later in this chapter) **Nereus**, the eldest of his children, who was gentle, wise, and true, an old man of the sea with the gift of prophecy. Nereus in turn united with Doris (an Oceanid) who bore him fifty daughters, the **Nereids**; three of these mermaids should be singled out: Thetis, Galatea, and Amphitrite.

Peleus and Thetis

We have already mentioned that Thetis was destined to bear a son mightier than his father. Zeus learned this secret from Prometheus and avoided mating with Thetis; she married instead a mortal named Peleus, who was hard pressed to catch his bride. For Thetis possessed